

Biplanes Dominate

Lessons learned from World War I were consolidated into stronger, faster, and more efficient military aircraft. Britain and the US still favored biplanes, but now with steel frames and innovations including supercharged engines, hydraulic wheel brakes, and landing flaps. France preferred monoplanes, and built effective aircraft still with wood frames. Aircraft would be increasingly important in future conflict, as messengers and troop transports, not just fighters and bombers.



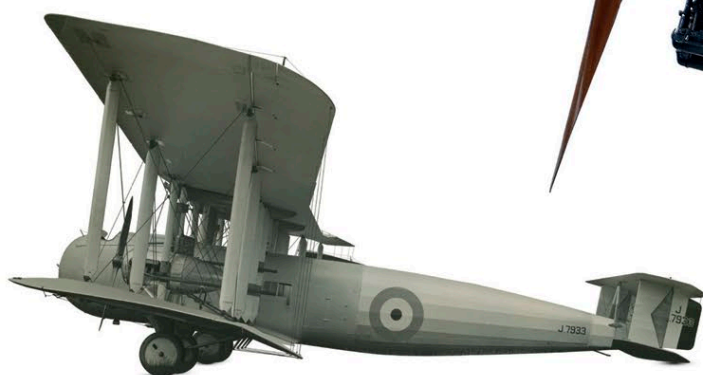
△ Verville-Sperry M-1 Messenger 1920

Origin USA

Engine 60hp Lawrance L-3 air-cooled 3-cylinder radial

Top speed 97 mph (156 km/h)

Small, simple, cheap, and designed by Alfred Verville to replace motorcycles carrying messages for the US Army Air Service, the M-1 was also used for research, including airship hookup.



△ Vickers Type 56 Victoria 1922

Origin UK

Engine 2 x 570hp Napier Lion XI liquid-cooled Broad Arrow

Top speed N/A

WWI showed that getting troops into place before the enemy would be crucial in future conflicts, so the RAF ordered these troop transports. They served until 1944, with new engines fitted in the 1930s.



△ Boeing Model 15 FB-5 Hawk 1923

Origin USA

Engine 520hp Packard 2A-1500 liquid-cooled V12

Top speed 159 mph (256 km/h)

Boeing analyzed WWI Fokker DVIIIs before building the Model 15 pursuit fighter, which served with the USAAF and with the US Navy. The FB-5 was the production carrier-borne variant.



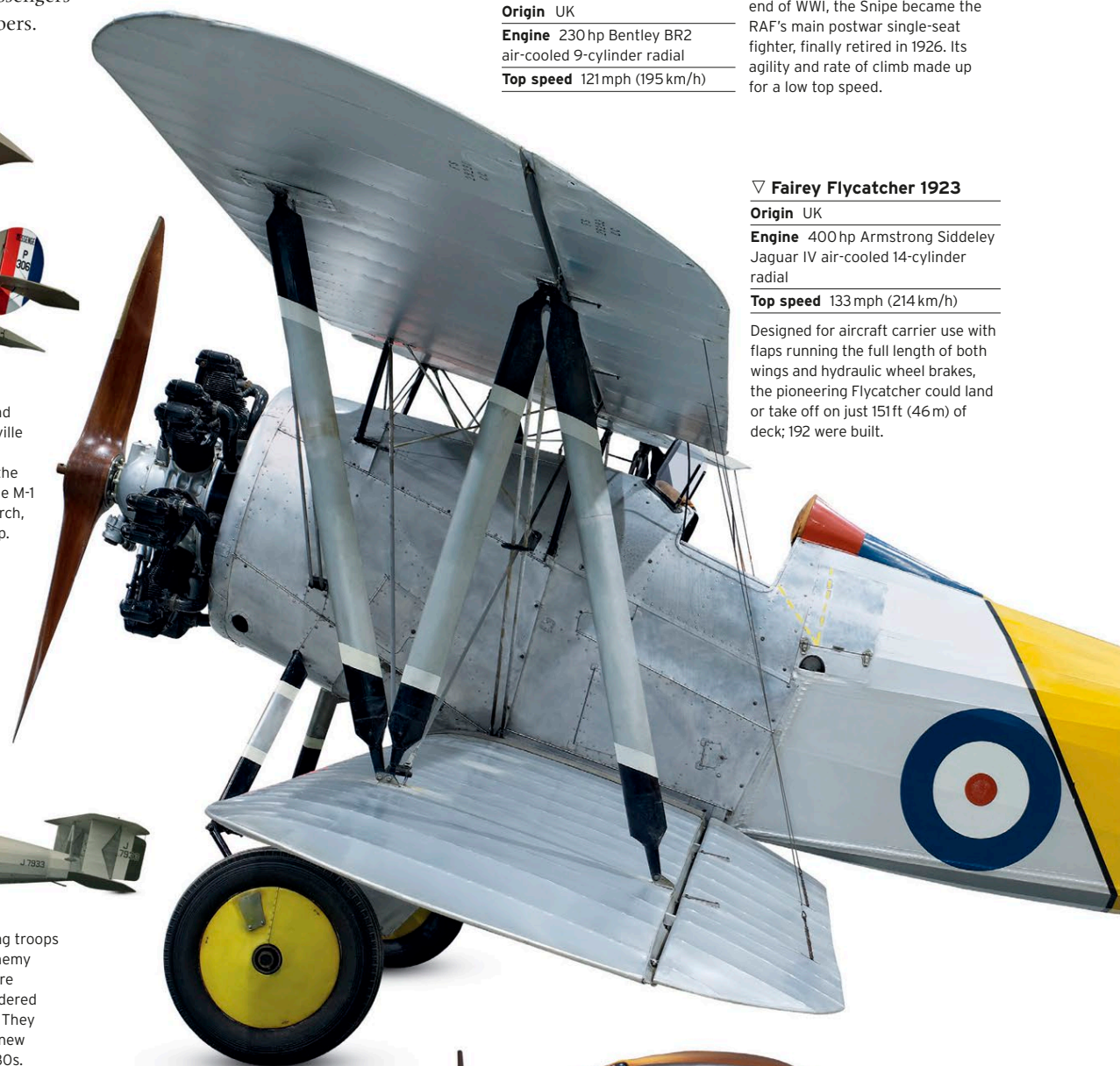
△ Sopwith 7F.1 Snipe 1919

Origin UK

Engine 230hp Bentley BR2 air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 121 mph (195 km/h)

Introduced a few weeks before the end of WWI, the Snipe became the RAF's main postwar single-seat fighter, finally retired in 1926. Its agility and rate of climb made up for a low top speed.



▽ Fairey Flycatcher 1923

Origin UK

Engine 400hp Armstrong Siddeley Jaguar IV air-cooled 14-cylinder radial

Top speed 133 mph (214 km/h)

Designed for aircraft carrier use with flaps running the full length of both wings and hydraulic wheel brakes, the pioneering Flycatcher could land or take off on just 151ft (46m) of deck; 192 were built.



△ Boeing F4B-4 1928

Origin USA

Engine 550hp Pratt & Whitney 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 189 mph (304 km/h)

A compact, light, and agile fighter for the US Navy, the F4B (or P-12) flew from the USS Lexington from 1929 and served as a pursuit fighter until the mid-1930s, then on training duties until 1941.